two of the three incidents. It was a clear case of some unsavoury anti-national elements trying to further their own agenda.

I came to know of the initial incident on the 4th evening itself, when the Army Commander Lt Gen Manoj Pande rang me up.[4] We were still digesting this information when the news of the second incident came in. I rang up the RM, NSA and the CDS as I realized that this incident was going to hit the headlines. The NSA was, of course, perturbed, as this incident was sure to affect the discussions on the Naga Peace Accord that were ongoing, but nevertheless said that it was a good thing that I had told him so that he could straightaway do some damage control. The next day, 3 Corps and Eastern Command issued a formal statement that the ambush was a result of mistaken identity and expressed regret over the incident. It was while we were actually trying to defuse the situation that the attack on the AR camp at Mon took place.

Over the next couple of days, there was intense pressure on us to declare some punitive disciplinary action. But against whom? The team had launched the operation based on credible intelligence and had been shadowing this group of terrorists for some time. Oting is in the vicinity of illegal coal mines and therefore the hub of extortion activities. Hence, it was reasonable to expect terrorist movements in the area. Errors of omission and commission would only emerge through a proper inquiry, and only then could action be taken against anyone. This knee-jerk reaction had to be avoided. Accordingly, Eastern Command immediately ordered a high-level Court of Inquiry to be headed by the GOC, 2 Mtn Div. Despite several hints to at least 'suspend' someone, anyone, we decided to await the outcome of the inquiry, which was completed in record time. I remembered my time as CO, 2 RR and the operations we had conducted, not all of which were successful. My superiors had

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